

INTERNAL

Information Labelling Training

ISO 27001 Control 5.13 - Training Materials

Document ID: ISMS-TRAIN-LAB-001

Version: 2.0

Training Duration: 45-60 minutes

Last Updated: January 2025

Trainer: Information Security Team

Status: Active

Learning Objectives

By the end of this training, you will be able to:

- Understand the importance of information labelling in protecting organizational assets
- Identify and apply the correct classification labels to different types of information
- Follow proper labelling procedures for physical and electronic documents
- Recognize your responsibilities in handling labelled information
- Apply best practices for information classification and labelling

1. Introduction to Information Labelling

1.1 What is Information Labelling?

Information labelling is the process of marking documents, files, emails, and other information assets with classification labels that indicate their sensitivity level and handling requirements. Proper labelling ensures that information is protected according to its value and sensitivity to the organization.

1.2 Why is Information Labelling Important?

- **Protection:** Prevents unauthorized access, disclosure, or loss of sensitive information
- **Compliance:** Meets legal and regulatory requirements (GDPR, ISO 27001, industry standards)
- **Risk Management:** Reduces the risk of data breaches and security incidents
- **Awareness:** Helps employees understand how to handle different types of information
- **Accountability:** Creates clear responsibility for information protection

 **Important:** Failure to properly label and handle information can result in data breaches, financial losses, legal penalties, and reputational damage to the organization.

2. Information Classification Scheme

Our organization uses a four-tier classification scheme. Each classification level has specific handling requirements and controls.

PUBLIC **Public Information**

Definition: Information that is intended for public release and can be freely shared without any risk to the organization.

Examples:

- Published annual reports and marketing materials
- Press releases and public website content
- Job advertisements and general company information
- Product brochures and public presentations

Handling Requirements:

- No special restrictions on distribution or storage
- Can be shared via any communication channel
- No encryption required

INTERNAL **Internal Use Only**

Definition: Information intended for use within the organization. Unauthorized disclosure could cause minor inconvenience or embarrassment but not significant harm.

Examples:

- Internal policies and procedures
- Department budgets and operational plans

- Employee directories and internal newsletters
- Meeting minutes (non-sensitive)
- Training materials and internal communications

Handling Requirements:

- Share only with employees, authorized contractors, and partners
- Do not post on public websites or social media
- Store in password-protected systems
- Use secure email when sharing externally with approved parties

CONFIDENTIAL Confidential Information

Definition: Sensitive information that requires protection. Unauthorized disclosure could cause significant harm to the organization, including financial loss, legal liability, or competitive disadvantage.

Examples:

- Employee personal information (HR records, salaries, performance reviews)
- Customer data and contracts
- Financial reports (pre-publication)
- Business strategies and plans
- Non-public product development information
- Audit reports and security assessments

Handling Requirements:

- Share only on a need-to-know basis with authorized personnel
- Encrypt when transmitting electronically
- Store in secure, access-controlled locations

- Require non-disclosure agreements for external parties
- Shred or securely delete when no longer needed
- Do not discuss in public areas

RESTRICTED Restricted Information

Definition: Highly sensitive information that must be protected with the highest level of security. Unauthorized disclosure could cause severe harm including major financial loss, legal action, or serious reputational damage.

Examples:

- Intellectual property and trade secrets
- M&A documents and strategic negotiations
- Security credentials and cryptographic keys
- Legal privileged communications
- Board meeting materials (confidential)
- Incident response plans and vulnerability reports

Handling Requirements:

- Access limited to specifically authorized individuals only
- Must be encrypted at rest and in transit
- Require multi-factor authentication for access
- Store in physically secure locations with access logs
- Document all access and distribution
- Formal approval required for any sharing
- Secure destruction required (witnessed and certified)

3. Labelling Procedures

3.1 When to Label Information

All information assets must be labelled when they are:

- Created or received
- Modified or updated
- Shared or distributed
- Stored or archived

 **Best Practice:** When in doubt about the appropriate classification level, always classify information at a higher level and consult with your manager or the Information Security Team.

3.2 How to Label Electronic Documents

Electronic Document Labelling Process

1 Determine Classification Level

Review the content and determine the appropriate classification based on the sensitivity and impact of unauthorized disclosure.

2 Apply Label in Document

Insert the classification label in the header or footer of the document:

- **Header:** Right-aligned or centered at the top of each page

- **Footer:** Centered at the bottom of each page

3 Label File Name (if appropriate)

For highly sensitive documents (CONFIDENTIAL or RESTRICTED), consider including the classification in the filename:

Example: [CONFIDENTIAL] Q4 Financial Report 2024.xlsx

4 Set Document Properties

Use document metadata to record classification level in document properties where possible.

5 Label Email Subject Line

When sharing classified documents via email, include the classification in the subject line:

Example: [CONFIDENTIAL] Contract Review – Project Alpha

3.3 How to Label Physical Documents

Physical Document Labelling Requirements:

- **Stamp or Label:** Apply classification stamp or label at the top and bottom of each page
- **Color Coding:** Use colored paper or labels:
 - Public: No special color
 - Internal: Yellow

- Confidential: Orange
- Restricted: Red
- **Folders/Envelopes:** Clearly mark containers holding classified documents
- **Cover Sheets:** Use cover sheets for CONFIDENTIAL and RESTRICTED documents when in transit

3.4 Labelling Examples

Header/Footer Label PUBLIC	Header/Footer Label INTERNAL
Header/Footer Label CONFIDENTIAL	Header/Footer Label RESTRICTED

4. Handling Labelled Information

4.1 Quick Reference Guide

Activity	PUBLIC	INTERNAL	CONFIDENTIAL	RESTRICTED
Email Distribution	Any recipient	Internal + approved partners	Authorized personnel only, encrypted	Approved list only, encrypted
Printing	Any printer	Internal printers only	Secure printers, collect immediately	Authorized secure printer only
Storage	No restrictions	Password-protected systems	Encrypted storage, access-controlled	Encrypted + audit logging
Physical Security	None required	Lock when unattended	Locked cabinet/drawer	Safe or secure room
Disposal	Normal trash/delete	Shred or secure delete	Cross-cut shred or certified deletion	Witnessed destruction + certificate
Discussion	Anywhere	Office environments	Private areas only	Secure rooms only
Mobile Devices	Allowed	Allowed with encryption	Encrypted + MDM required	Prohibited unless specifically approved

4.2 Special Handling Scenarios

Scenario 1: Sharing Information Externally

Before sharing any classified information with external parties:

1. Verify the recipient is authorized to receive it
2. Ensure a Non-Disclosure Agreement (NDA) is in place for CONFIDENTIAL or RESTRICTED information
3. Use secure transmission methods (encrypted email, secure file transfer)
4. Include handling instructions with the information
5. Document the disclosure (who, what, when, why)

Scenario 2: Changing Classification Levels

Downgrading Classification: Information may be downgraded when it's no longer sensitive (e.g., after public release). This requires approval from the information owner and documentation of the change.

Upgrading Classification: If information becomes more sensitive, immediately upgrade the classification, relabel the document, and notify all recipients.

Scenario 3: Working Remotely

⚠ Remote Work Considerations:

- Use only approved VPN connections for accessing classified information
- Ensure home network is secured with strong password
- Never access CONFIDENTIAL or RESTRICTED information on public WiFi

- Use privacy screens when working in public spaces
- Lock your screen when away from your device
- Do not print classified documents on home printers unless approved

5. Your Responsibilities

5.1 Employee Obligations

As an employee, you are responsible for:

- ☐ Properly classifying and labelling all information you create or handle
- ☐ Applying appropriate security controls based on classification labels
- ☐ Protecting classified information from unauthorized access or disclosure
- ☐ Reporting any suspected or actual security incidents immediately
- ☐ Challenging unclear or missing classification labels
- ☐ Following organizational policies and procedures for information handling
- ☐ Completing required information security training annually
- ☐ Understanding that you can be held accountable for mishandling classified information

5.2 Manager/Information Owner Responsibilities

Managers and information owners have additional responsibilities:

- Define appropriate classification for information under their control
- Approve access to CONFIDENTIAL and RESTRICTED information
- Review and update classification levels periodically
- Ensure team members are trained on labelling procedures
- Monitor compliance with information handling requirements
- Investigate and address policy violations

 **Remember:** When creating a new document, always ask yourself: "What would happen if this information was disclosed to unauthorized parties?" This will help you determine the appropriate classification level.

6. Common Mistakes to Avoid

Mistake	Why It's Wrong	Correct Action
Not labelling documents at all	Others won't know how to handle the information properly	Always label documents according to their sensitivity
Under-classifying sensitive information	Information may not receive adequate protection	When in doubt, classify at a higher level
Over-classifying routine information	Creates unnecessary restrictions and reduces productivity	Use the lowest appropriate classification
Removing or ignoring labels	Defeats the purpose of classification system	Maintain labels throughout document lifecycle
Sharing login credentials	Bypasses access controls and creates accountability issues	Never share credentials; request proper access
Discussing confidential matters in public	Risk of unauthorized disclosure or eavesdropping	Only discuss sensitive topics in private settings
Using personal email for work documents	Lack of security controls and organizational oversight	Always use company email and approved systems

Mistake	Why It's Wrong	Correct Action
Leaving classified documents visible	Risk of unauthorized viewing or theft	Use clear desk policy; lock documents away